

Lease protection strategies, legal recourse for tenant debt, financial recovery methods — Action Checklist

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UNDERSTAND YOUR LEASE EXPOSURE

- ☐ **Find Liability Language:** Pull out your lease agreement today and search for "joint," "liable," "several," or "responsible" in the rent payment or obligations sections to confirm how your shared liability is structured.
- ☐ **Calculate Financial Exposure:** Multiply your monthly rent by the remaining months on your lease to determine your worst-case financial liability if your roommate stops paying entirely.
- ☐ **Verify State and Local Laws:** Research your state and city housing regulations to find out whether any laws require individual liability language in multi-tenant leases, which could limit your exposure.
- ☐ **Get Lease Explanations in Writing:** Contact your landlord or property manager to ask for clarification on your lease terms, and request any verbal explanations be provided via email or letter to create a paper trail.

DOCUMENT AND RECOVER THE DEBT

- ☐ **Document Every Missed Payment Immediately:** Start a written log today recording each date your roommate fails to pay their share, the amount owed, and how you communicated about it, whether through text messages, emails, or written notes.
- ☐ **Send a Formal Debt Demand Letter:** Draft and send a certified letter to your roommate stating the exact amount they owe, the specific time period covered, and a deadline for repayment that creates a legal record.
- ☐ **File a Small Claims Court Action:** Sue your roommate in small claims court for the documented unpaid rent amount, keeping filing fees low and no requirement for an attorney to pursue financial recovery.
- ☐ **Negotiate a Settlement Agreement:** Approach any debt recovery negotiation by getting any settlement amount or repayment plan in writing and signed by both parties before agreeing to any arrangement that forgives part of the debt.

STRENGTHEN FUTURE PROTECTION

- ☐ **Negotiate Lease Modifications at Renewal:** Request your landlord add an individual responsibility clause or break clause to your lease renewal that limits your liability to only your portion of the rent before signing.
 - ☐ **Separate Your Rent Payment:** Set up your own payment method directly with the landlord so you can prove you paid your exact share, keeping payment records completely independent from your roommate's transactions.
 - ☐ **Open a Separate Dispute Account:** Create a dedicated financial account to track all money owed to you by your roommate, including amounts, dates, and repayment agreements, so you have a clear record of the debt.
 - ☐ **Protect Your Credit Now:** Monitor your credit report regularly and address any damage from missed rent payments immediately by disputing errors and working to rebuild your score after resolving the roommate situation.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.